

From Clefts to Definiteness in Bangla and Beyond[‡]

ABSTRACT

I provide empirical support for the claim that the definiteness of a DP can be decomposed into an existential quantifier and a cleft operator attached to the restrictor of this quantifier. As empirical evidence, I provide novel data from Bangla, where exactly the kind of DPs that otherwise do not allow a definite reading suddenly allows a definite reading when a cleft morpheme is put on top of them. I point out how this account is similar to and different from other decompositional accounts of definites and the consequences of this new account for the English data that motivated the other decompositional accounts.

Word count: 15016

Keywords: definiteness, uniqueness, presupposition, Strong Kleene, local accommodation, clefts, PEX.

1 Introduction

The goal of this paper is to present a novel data pattern from the definite-indefinite distinction in Bangla, connect it to an existing idea in the literature, and thus, furnish evidence for this idea from outside of English. The main paradigm of interest is (1), the gist of which is that certain Bangla DPs, namely, DPs with numerals, which otherwise behave like indefinites, start behaving like definites when a cleft morpheme *[-i]* is attached to them.¹ (1a) shows that when the numeral, in a Bangla DP with a numeral, linearly precedes the noun, the indefinite meaning arises. (1b) shows that when the linear order of the numeral and the noun are switched and everything else remains the same, the DP behaves like a definite, instead of an indefinite. This alternation has been known since [Bhattacharya \(1998, 1999\)](#), [Dayal \(2012\)](#).² The interesting fact, as shown in (1c), is that when the cleft morpheme (glossed as “FOC” throughout the paper) is attached to a DP with the numeral-first order, it is no longer confined to its indefinite meaning; instead, the following ambiguity arises: either the DP can be interpreted as a definite or the entire sentence can be interpreted as a cleft where the focus associate is an indefinite DP.

[‡]. Acknowledgements to be added.

1. All Bangla glosses are given in the IPA. All Bangla judgements are the author’s.

2. References are always given alphabetically.

- (1) a. ami **du-to** **boi** poṭ-etʰ-i.
 1.SG.NOM **two-CLF** **book** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “I’ve read two books.”
- b. ami **boi** **du-to** poṭ-etʰ-i.
 1.SG.NOM **book** **two-CLF** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “I’ve read the two books.”
- c. ami **du-to** **boi-i** poṭ-etʰ-i.
 1.SG.NOM **two-CLF** **book-FOC** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “It’s two books that I have read.”
 “I have read the two books.”

What this pattern is telling us is that the meaning of definiteness can be analyzed as decomposable into two parts: existential quantification and the presuppositional nature of definites which makes them minimally different from indefinites, *i.e.*, uniqueness. This idea about the decomposability of the definite into an existential part and a uniqueness part is familiar from certain approaches to definites in the literature, *e.g.*, Bumford (2017a,b, 2018), Coppock & Beaver (2012a,b, 2014, 2015), Doron (2025). **In this paper, I want to adduce the data in (1) as support in favor of the idea that such a decomposition is at least one possible source of definiteness (with more empirical details in section 2).** While I begin by pointing out how the existing approaches are pertinent to the data at hand (section 3), in my own analysis of them, I will characterize the decomposition in a slightly different way (sections 5.1 and 5.2), since, in (1), what seems to make the crucial difference is the addition of a cleft morpheme (as opposed to Bumford’s *tests/filters* and Coppock & Beaver’s 2015 use of Partee’s 1986 *ι* operator). This will end up providing a new perspective on these existing approaches by adding the semantics of clefts to the list of ways the meaning of uniqueness/maximality arises separately from the meaning of existence in definites. In addition to this, for the sake of completeness, I will also provide an account of the linear-order-based alternation between indefiniteness and definiteness in Bangla discussed in Bhattacharya (1998, 1999), Dayal (2012), which will make reference to the compositional semantics of definites (section 5.3). Such an account of this phenomenon would not have been possible under their previous discussions on Bangla because examples like (1c) were not considered by them. The existing literature on the relevant Bangla facts is briefly reviewed in section 4.

2 The Bangla facts

As Bhattacharya (1998, 1999), Dayal (2012) have discussed, Bangla DPs with a numeral linearly preceding the noun (henceforth, “numeral-first DPs”) behave like an indefinite, while those with a numeral linearly following the noun (henceforth, “noun-first DPs”) behave like definites. This can be demonstrated from various aspects of the distinctions known to exist between definites and indefinites. For my purposes here, what will allow me to make

my point most succinctly is the difference in terms of the presence/absence of a uniqueness/maximality presupposition. (2) shows that numeral-first DPs in Bangla do not carry a uniqueness/maximality presupposition, while noun-first DPs do. The first sentence in (2a) is infelicitous in the given context, because it comes with an implicature that no more than two women are ill. But this can be canceled, as shown by the second sentence in the discourse. This indicates that the numeral-first order does not come with a uniqueness/maximality presupposition. This contrasts critically with the noun-first order in (2c).

(2) **Context:** Charu, Monda, and Aparna (all of whom are women) are ill.

- a. **du-ɕon mofila** ɔjust^ho. bɔl-a b^{fi}alo, **tin-ɕon mofila** ɔjust^ho.
two-CLF woman ill say-NMLZ good three-CLF woman ill
“Two women are ill. It’s better to say that three women are ill.”
- b. **tin-ɕon mofila** ɔjust^ho.
three-CLF woman ill
“Three women are ill.”
- c. #**mofila du-ɕon** ɔjust^ho.
woman two-CLF ill
“The two women are ill.”
- d. **mofila tin-ɕon** ɔjust^ho.
woman three-CLF ill
“The three women are ill.”

As a result of this, the interaction between these two kinds of DP is identical to the kind of interaction that is observed between *a boy* and *the boy* in English. That is, when the uniqueness/maximality presupposition is satisfied, the noun-first order must be used, and the numeral-first order incurs infelicity, as shown in (3), which is often explained by competition between indefinites and definites governed by MAXIMIZE PRESUPPOSITION (Heim 1991, Percus 2006, Sauerland 2003, 2008, Schlenker 2012). (3a) shows that the numeral-first order is not acceptable, where the cardinality of the noun’s denotation is exactly the same as the numeral’s denotation. That is, it behaves exactly like the indefinite *two legs of mine*, which is predicted by MAXIMIZE PRESUPPOSITION. (3b) shows that the noun-first order is acceptable, and this can be made sense of, because the noun-first order signals definiteness.

(3) **Context:** The speaker has broken both of their legs.

- a. #ama-r **du-to pa** b^{fi}ej-e gætj^h-e.
1.SG-GEN two-CLF leg break-GER go-PERF-PRS.3
“Two legs of mine have broken.”
- b. ama-r **pa du-to** b^{fi}ej-e gætj^h-e.
1.SG-GEN leg two-CLF break-GER go-PERF-PRS.3
“My two legs have broken.”

The crucial fact of interest here is that when the cleft morpheme *[-i]* is attached to numeral-first DPs, they acquire the option to behave like a definite, despite its numeral-first linear order. This becomes most clear, again, in contexts where MAXIMIZE PRESUPPOSITION is relevant, for instance (4). This example is meant to be judged in the same context as (3). The crucial difference between (3a) and (4) is that numeral-first *[-i]* DPs are acceptable in the context where numeral-first DPs without *[-i]* are not, which can be straightforwardly explained if they have a reading that behaves like the definite in (3b), and not like the indefinite in (3a). Therefore, this provides explicit evidence in favor of the definite reading of numeral-first *[-i]* DPs.

- (4) **Context:** The speaker has broken both of their legs.
 ama-r **du-to** **pa-i** b^hej-e gætʃ^h-e.
 1.SG-GEN **two-CLF** **leg-FOC** break-GER go-PERF-PRS.3
 “My two legs have broken.”

Furthermore, it is not just this definite reading that appears in sentences with numeral-first *[-i]* DPs. These are, in fact, ambiguous between a definite reading (as shown in (4)) and the meaning of a sentence with a plain indefinite focus associate. I will call this *the cleft reading* (the reason for this will be made clear shortly). The possibility of the cleft reading with an indefinite focus associate is shown in (5). The context makes it clear here that, since the number of fingers is concerned, there are (usually) ten of them. Therefore, if *finger* is felicitously modified by a numeral less than *ten*, then, because of the uniqueness/maximality presupposition of definites, the DP with the numeral can only be an indefinite. In other words, numeral-first DPs with *[-i]* do not *have* to have the definite reading shown in (4).

- (5) **Context:** All of Amol’s fingers have been injured more or less from an accident, and
 ...
 o-r **du-to** **anjul-i** ket-etʃ^h-e.
 3.SG-GEN **two-CLF** **finger-FOC** cut-PERF-PRS.3
 “... it’s two of his fingers that have been cut.”

The cleft reading, made salient by (5), is unsurprising, given *[-i]* is an exhaustive focus-marking morpheme in Bangla. (6) exemplifies a fairly common usage of this morpheme. This example is supposed to demonstrate its exhaustivizing effect. The first sentence in (6a), for instance, which does not give an exhaustive list of the people who came, can be followed up by the second sentence, which provides information about who else came as well. This is impossible in (6b), where the *[-i]* in the first sentence conveys that Amol is the only person who came, thus making the second sentence infelicitous.

- (6) a. ɒmol ef-etʃʰ-e. ʈfaru-o ef-etʃʰ-e.
 Amol.NOM come-PERF-PRS.3 Charu.NOM-ADD come-PERF-PRS.3
 “Amol has come. Charu has come too.”
- b. $\# \text{ɒmol-i}$ ef-etʃʰ-e. ʈfaru-o ef-etʃʰ-e.
Amol.NOM-FOC come-PERF-PRS.3 Charu.NOM-ADD come-PERF-PRS.3
 “It’s Amol who has come. Charu has come too.”

The reason I describe this morpheme as *the cleft morpheme* is that, firstly, just like English clefts, it comes with an existence presupposition. For instance, in the context provided in (7), an unclefted polar question about the identity of the visitor, e.g., (7a), is felicitous, but a clefted polar question with the potential visitor as the focus associate is not. This is consistent with the standard existence presupposition assumed for clefts, which, in the case of (7b), would be *Someone has come*, and this presupposition is not met in the context.

- (7) **Context:** There is no common knowledge that someone is at the door. For instance, the doorbell has not rung and there has been no other sign that someone is at the door.
- a. ɒmol ki ef-etʃʰ-e?
 Amol.NOM Q_{Y/N} come-PERF-PRS.3
 “Has Amol come?”
- b. $\# \text{ɒmol-i}$ ki ef-etʃʰ-e?
Amol.NOM-FOC Q_{Y/N} come-PERF-PRS.3
 # “Is it Amol who has come?”

Secondly, just as in English (see (8)), sentences with *[-i]*, like (6b), come with an exhaustivity inference, which is not part of its at-issue content, as shown in (9) (the status of which has been a subject of debate; see, e.g., [Atlas & Levinson 1981](#), [Büring 2011](#), [Büring & Križ 2013](#), [Halvorsen 1978](#), [Horn 1981](#), [Velleman et al. 2012](#)). This is distinct from the behavior of contrastive focus, as shown in (10). Therefore, the accurate way to characterize the *[-i]* morpheme is to say it is *a cleft morpheme*, instead of something more general, like *a focus morpheme*.

- (8) a. $\#$ She invited Fred, but it wasn’t Fred she invited.
 b. She invited Fred, but she didn’t invite only Fred.

([Büring & Križ 2013](#), (4): 2)

- (9) #*ɔmol* *ʒan-t-o* *ʒe* *ami* *eḷ* *ʒama-ta* *por-b-o*. *aʒ*
 Amol.NOM know-HAB-PST.3 that 1.SG.NOM this dress-CLF wear-FUT-1 today
ʒan-l-o *ʒe* *ami* *eḷ* *ʒama-ta-i* *por-b-o*.
 know-PFV-PST.3 that 1.SG.NOM this dress-CLF-FOC wear-FUT-1

Intended:

#“Amol knew that I would wear this dress. Today, he found out that it’s this dress that I’ll wear.”

- (10) a. JOHN laughed, and so did MARY.
 b. #It was John who laughed, and so did MARY.

(Velleman et al. 2012, (4): 444)

This concludes the main bulk of the Bangla facts. To summarize, in Bangla, when the cleft morpheme is attached to certain DPs whose linear order would have signaled indefiniteness in the absence of the cleft morpheme behave like definites. This indicates that there should be a possible way to derive the meaning of definiteness from an underlying indefinite meaning, when the indefinite meaning is supplemented with the contribution made by the semantics of clefts. The idea that definites are decomposable into an indefinite and something else — this something else being the source of the uniqueness/maximality presupposition — is not new and have been developed along different lines in the literature. I now turn to take a look at this existing literature in order to determine which part of the behavior seen in Bangla can be addressed by these approaches.

3 The indefiniteness in definites

There are multiple proposals in the literature pursuing the idea that the meaning of definiteness should be broken up into one component of existence and another of uniqueness/maximality. One series of work in this vein has been done by Coppock and Beaver (2012a, 2012b, 2014, 2015), and another, by Bumford (2017a,b, 2018). I will address both of these. I begin with Coppock and Beaver. For the sake of brevity, I will concentrate on Coppock & Beaver (2015), which will be sufficient to appreciate the main points.

Coppock & Beaver’s (2015) starting point is that definite descriptions in predicative positions do not always lead to a uniqueness or existence inference, even in environments the uniqueness and existence presuppositions are predicted to project by conventional treatments of the definite determiner. If it did, then (11b) would be infelicitous in the given context, since the predicate *only author of Waverley* is an empty set, and *author of Waverley* is a non-singleton set. That is, although the felicity of (11a) in its own context in (11a) can be made sense of under the conventional view of uniqueness in definites, that of (11b) cannot.

- (11) a. **Context:**
The speaker is in the world we live in, where Scott is the only author of *Waverley*.
Scott is the only author of *Waverley*. [1 author]
- b. **Context:**
The speaker is in a world different from ours, where someone co-authored *Waverley* with Scott.
Scott is not the only author of *Waverley*. [> 1 author]

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (2): 380)

Based on this, Coppock & Beaver's (2015) propose, as the basic contribution of a definite, a component that encodes the possibility of existence, thereby allowing for the possibility of non-existence as well, for cases like (11b). To this end, they propose the lexical entry for *the* in (12). The presupposition of this entry is that its argument is either the empty set or a singleton set. The possibility of the empty set allows for the case of non-existence. (11a) remains unproblematic for this entry for obvious reasons. But it makes a crucial difference for (11b): this sentence is no longer undefined because the non-existence of the only author of *Waverley* in the context in (11b) is subsumed under the " $|P| \leq 1$ " condition.

$$(12) \quad \llbracket \text{the} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \lambda x_e : |P| \leq 1 . P(x) = 1$$

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (50): 395; notation modified)

This is Coppock & Beaver's (2015) proposal for definites in predicative positions, as in (11). To account for the uniqueness/maximality presupposition for definites in cases like *John read/did not read the book*, they adopt Partee's (1986) ι operator, given in (13). Existence is ensured by stipulating undefinedness if there is no unique element satisfying the description of the predicate argument of ι . Besides contributing the meaning of uniqueness/maximality, this ι operator also type-shifts the $\langle e, t \rangle$ -type output of *the* into an e -type denotation, so that definites can be interpreted in argumental positions.

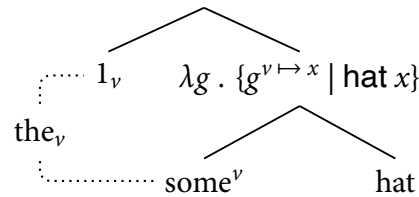
$$(13) \quad \llbracket \iota \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \text{ if there is a unique } x \text{ such that } P(x) = 1, \text{ then the unique } y \text{ such that } P(y) = 1; \text{ undefined otherwise}$$

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (84), (86): 408; rephrased for my purposes)

Another existing proposal for definites breaking it up into an existential meaning and a uniqueness/maximality meaning is the one developed in Bumford (2017a,b, 2018). His implementation is couched within a compositional dynamic semantics (similar to that of Charlow 2017). Keeping with that, the indefinite part of the meaning he proposes as one part of a definite is envisioned exactly as an indefinite would, in dynamic semantics in general, that is, as introducing a discourse referent. Then, what Bumford refers to as a *test* makes

sure that the same entity is allocated to this discourse referent across all potential output assignments. A test 1_v is an identity function, if the update it takes as its argument is constant across its assignments for the discourse referent v (at some input g); otherwise, it returns the degenerate update $\lambda g . \emptyset$. In other words, the test is the component that ensures uniqueness/maximality. This is shown in (14), for the isolated expression *the hat*. The dotted line is intended to mean that the test and the indefinite together give rise to the meaning of definiteness.

$$(14) \quad \lambda g . \begin{cases} G & \text{if } |G_v| = 1, \text{ where } G = \{g^v \mapsto x \mid \text{hat } x\} \\ \emptyset & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

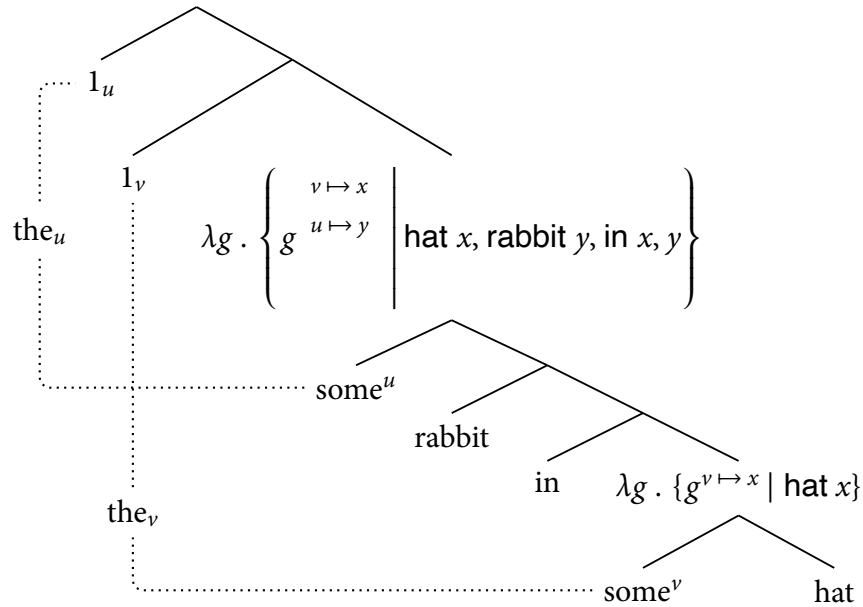


(Bumford 2017a, Fig. 1: 550)

Bumford's reason for adopting this analysis is that he wants to make it possible for there to be some structural distance between the point in semantic composition where the indefinite is introduced and that at which the test is introduced. Such a delay is necessary to explain the felicity of sentences containing expressions like (15a) in contexts where there is more than one hat but only one rabbit-containing hat — an observation going back to at least Haddock (1987). When the test for the discourse referent for the hat is delayed until the discourse referent for the rabbit is also introduced by interleaving the tests and the indefinites as in (15b), it becomes possible to ensure the uniqueness of a rabbit-containing hat, because, during that delay, the discourse referent for the rabbit and the words denoting the containment relationship have already been introduced into the structure.

- (15) a. the rabbit in the hat (Haddock 1987)

b.



(Bumford 2017a, Fig. 2: 551)

These two analyses are similar in the way they relate to the Bangla data in (1). Basically, both of these analyses have to explain why it is the cleft morpheme that is at the center of the Bangla facts in (1). Of course, it cannot be held against either of them that they do not have the ingredients to explain the difference between noun-first DPs (unambiguous, always definite; see (1b)) and numeral-first DPs with *[-i]* (ambiguous between the definite reading and the cleft reading; see (1c)) in Bangla, because they were interested in much simpler and more well-known cases from English. But these two accounts are compositional in a similar way: both of them decompose the meaning of definites into existence and uniqueness/maximality. Given this decomposition, it is natural to think of the existence part of the meaning as an indefinite, which would mean that definiteness is the net result of combining an indefinite with something else responsible for uniqueness/maximality coming together. This division of labor seems to exactly correspond to what the paradigm in (1) seems to be telling us, where, also, we see an indefinite gaining the option to behave like a definite once something else is added to it. Given this parallel, one would hope to be able to capture the facts in (1) within these existing approaches. And they seem to almost be able to do that, except that they do not incorporate cleft semantics into their picture. What I will suggest in this paper, then, is to keep this compositional idea intact, but adopt a different route to uniqueness/maximality that does not involve an ι operator (as in Coppock and Beaver) or a test (as in Bumford), but a focus-sensitive operator that is independently responsible for cleft semantics. Therefore, this paper should be thought of as a way to render a version of these existing approaches that is fine-grained enough to establish a link between definiteness and cleft semantics, so that a unified analysis can be given for the Bangla facts and the facts that originally motivated Coppock and Beaver, and Bumford.

There is a sense in which it is not surprising at all that the uniqueness/maximality component of the meaning of definiteness seems to correlate with the meaning of cleft in Bangla, because, there is a component of exhaustivity that plays a fundamental role in the semantics of both clefts and definites: in the case of definites, the referent of a definite description must exhaust the characteristic set of the noun in the definite description. This point about exhaustivity has already been pointed out in by von Fintel et al. (2014), who call it *maximal informativity*. But this specific link is not fully explicit in the semantic machinery proposed in the two strands of work discussed above, which is why it is hard to imagine how one might give a treatment for the distinction between (1b) and (1c), based on their original systems. Articulating the link between clefts and definites, therefore, is one of the central themes of this paper.

Another theme of this paper related to prior literature — which only becomes clear towards the end of it — is the mobility of the part of the definite that is responsible for uniqueness/maximality, more specifically, the focus-sensitive operator. Sharvit (2015) has already proposed an account of data like (11), which involves moving *only* out of the DP. Following her lead, I would propose a similar account for (15) in contexts where there is only one rabbit-containing hat, regardless of how many hats there are. This would involve moving the focus-sensitive operator out of the DP, leaving the existential part of the meaning downstairs, thus removing the problem of presupposition failure of *the hat*. In other words, I take stock of the data previously discussed in Coppock and Beaver, and Bumford, by combining my idea of a focus-sensitive operator with Sharvit’s strategy of moving this operator out of the DP it is base-generated in.

4 The existing approaches for the Bangla facts

Before I get to my account, I will include a very brief consideration of what has already been said about at least part of the facts presented in (1) in Bhattacharya (1998, 1999), Dayal (2012). The concerns in Bhattacharya (1998, 1999) are mostly syntactic. Even when he addresses semantic questions, he formulates his proposal in terms of syntactic machinery which has no intuitive link to the semantics of clefts. He describes DPs with the numeral-first order as being *non-specific* and those with the noun-first order *specific*. He proposes that the derivation of (1b) involves a movement of the NP past the numeral, which is absent in the derivation of (1a). This movement, he proposes, is governed by the feature [SPECIFICITY] that is present on the relevant head³ in a specific DP. This feature forces the NP to move to the specifier of this head, resulting in the noun-first order in (1b), while, in a non-specific DP, a head with a different featural specification is merged, resulting in no movement, that is, the numeral-first order in (1a). There is no reason to oppose this analysis, given the alternation in linear order between (1a) and (1b). However, as I said above, this is spelled out entirely in terms of the syntax. I do not see a way, under Bhattacharya’s way of doing things, to connect this alternation to the nitty-gritty of cleft semantics, which, as I argue based on

3. This, for him, is the classifier head.

(1c), is a clear desideratum.

Dayal (2012) preserves the core of Bhattacharya’s proposal. Her main point related to the facts in (1) is that the linear order alternation has to do with definiteness *per se*, that is, uniqueness/maximality, and not specificity. I have fully adopted this and this is supported by the MAXIMIZE PRESUPPOSITION effects in section 2. Another aspect in which her approach differs from Bhattacharya’s is that she gives an explicitly semantic treatment of these DPs. However, much like Coppock & Beaver (2015), she encodes the uniqueness/maximality presupposition in the ι operator. Therefore, this approach, too, fails to shed light on how the facts in (1) are related to the semantics of clefts. I will now turn to my account of the facts.

5 The proposal

My proposal has three parts: (i) how the semantics of definites is related to the semantics of clefts and (ii) how this semantics achieves the final form of uniqueness/maximality, and (iii) how this semantics should be encoded in the syntax, so that the effects in (1) can be explained. I lay these out in three separate sections below.

5.1 The source of definiteness

In light of the Bangla facts in (1), I would adopt a way of connecting the source of the uniqueness/maximality presupposition of definites to an exhaustification operator. A specific version of this has been recently developed in Doron (2025). My analysis will preserve the spirit of Doron’s, but I will diverge from him at certain points. I will point them out as I go along.

Formally, I will assume a trivalent framework of presupposition projection (Beaver & Krahmer 2001, Fox 2008, 2013, George 2008a,b, Sudo et al. 2012). In this framework, instead of only the two classical truth values 1 and 0, a sentence (or any other propositional node in a tree) can receive three possible truth values: 1, 0, and #. The first two correspond to the classical notions of truth and falsity, respectively. The third value, #, stands for the truth value that is neither 1 nor 0, which, by assumption, is the truth value a sentence receives in the case of presupposition failure. Under this framework, the presupposition of a sentence (or any propositional node in a tree) is that it receives one of the classical truth values, which means that its presupposition can be written as the disjunction of its truth and falsity conditions.

My account of (1c) is that the sentence is ambiguous between two LFs given in (16), where $[-i]$ is the exhaustifying operator, specifically, the cleft operator, whose semantics is given in (18). (Here and in subsequent LFs, “ $\exists$ ” stands for the existential determiner head in the object language.) (16a) is the schema for the sentence in (1c). (16b) is the LF responsible for the cleft reading (just as in (6b), $[-i]$ originates on the indefinite and moves to the matrix level; see the discussion on (17) below for evidence of such a movement-based treatment) and (16c) is the LF responsible for the definite reading. The difference between the two LFs is that in the former LF, $[-i]$ has matrix scope, while in the latter, it takes scope inside the restrictor of the indefinite. Here, I totally follow Doron (2025) in locating the meaning of definiteness in an LF with an indefinite whose restrictor has been exhaustified.

- (16) a. I read two books- $[-i]$.
 b. $[-i^{st} [[\exists [\text{two book PL}]] \lambda_1 \text{ I read } t_1]]$
 c. $[[\exists [-i^{st} [\text{two book PL}]]] \lambda_1 \text{ I read } t_1]$

Following Hirsch (2017), I assume that $[-i]$, like other focus-sensitive operators such as *only*, always takes propositional scope. This is indicated by superfixing “*st*” to $[-i]$. Regarding its pronunciation adjacent to the focus associate, I propose that it originates on the focus associate and moves to a t -type node in narrow syntax; then, at LF, the lower copy is deleted, and, at PF, the higher copy is deleted. A movement-based analysis seems to be on the right track, given the site of $[-i]$ ’s pronunciation and its interpretation cannot be separated by an island boundary. For instance, consider (17b), in a context where each of the people being graded by B has read at least another book besides *Moses and Monotheism*. If $[-i]$ is analyzed as moving from inside the complex NP island in order to achieve matrix scope in B’s response, then the unacceptability of the intended meaning of B’s response, given A’s question, receives a straightforward explanation, since $[-i]$ should not be able to move out of an island. (17a) provides a baseline, which shows that, when matrix scope of $[-i]$ does not require movement out of a complex NP island, as in B’s response there, the result is felicitous. Intuitively, (17b) can be true only if every person being graded has read only *Moses and Monotheism*; but if $[-i]$ is able to associate with the focus-bearing phrase across an island boundary, then whether *Moses and Monotheism* is the only book read by people B graded should not affect the truth of B’s utterance, and the sentence should be judged true as long as *Moses and Monotheism* is a book read by everyone B graded.

- (17) a. A: $\underset{\cdot}{\text{tumi}}$ $\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{otem}$ æŋd $\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{æbu}$ $\text{po}^{\text{h}}\text{ɽ-}^{\text{h}}\text{et}^{\text{h}}\text{-o?}$
 2.SG.NOM totem and taboo read-PERF-PRS.2
 “Have you read *Totem and Taboo*?”
 B: na, $\underset{\cdot}{\text{ami}}$ **$\text{mo}^{\text{h}}\text{zes}$ æŋd $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{on}^{\text{h}}\text{ot}^{\text{h}}\text{iez}^{\text{h}}\text{æm-i}$** $\text{po}^{\text{h}}\text{ɽ-}^{\text{h}}\text{et}^{\text{h}}\text{-i.}$
 NEG 1.SG.NOM **Moses and monotheism-FOC** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “No, it’s *Moses and Monotheism* that I’ve read.”
 b. A: $\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{otem}$ æŋd $\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{æbu}$ $\text{po}^{\text{h}}\text{ɽ-}^{\text{h}}\text{et}^{\text{h}}\text{-e}$ æmon $\text{pro}^{\text{h}}\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{ek-ke}$ $\underset{\cdot}{\text{tumi}}$ gred
 totem and taboo read-PERF-PRS.3 such everyone-ACC 2.SG.NOM grade
 $\text{ko}^{\text{h}}\text{-}^{\text{h}}\text{et}^{\text{h}}\text{-o?}$
 do-PERF-PRS.2
 “Have you graded everyone who has read *Totem and Taboo*?”

B: #na, mozes æŋd mɒnɒt^hiezəm-i poɾ-ɛtʰ-e æmon proɾ:ek-ke
 NEG Moses and monotheism-FOC read-PERF-PRS.3 such everyone-ACC
 ami gred koɾ-ɛtʰ-i.
 1.SG.NOM grade do-PERF-PRS.1

Intended, but unavailable reading:

“No, it’s *Moses and Monotheism* such that I’ve graded everyone who has read it.”

Only available reading:

“No, I have graded everyone such that it is *Moses and Monotheism* that they have read.”

Moving on to the exact meaning of *[-i]*, I will adopt the semantics in (18) for it, with a simple version of the exhaustifying operator EXH, which just negates stronger alternatives. Notice that I am using the EXH operator in the metalanguage, but its metalanguage function is described by putting object language in double brackets. So, “ $\llbracket \text{EXH}^{st} \phi \rrbracket$ ” should be understood as the denotation of the result of combining EXH and ϕ , which would happen via Function Application. In a sense, the meaning is written by referring to a possibly hypothetical EXH operator in the object language, and this is done for ease of exposition and conceptualization. Whether EXH exists in the object language separately is orthogonal to my purposes here and I would like to remain agnostic about it. To reduce clutter, I omit C (the set of alternatives) in (18) (and wherever else it does not play a crucial role).^{4, 5}

$$\begin{aligned}
 (18) \quad & \llbracket -i^{st} C \phi \rrbracket \\
 &= \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } [\exists \psi \in C . \llbracket \psi \rrbracket = 1] \wedge \llbracket \text{EXH}^{st} \phi \rrbracket = 1 \\ 0 & \text{if } [\exists \psi \in C . \llbracket \psi \rrbracket = 1] \wedge \llbracket \neg \phi \rrbracket = 1 \\ \# & \text{if otherwise} \end{cases} \\
 &\rightsquigarrow \begin{cases} \text{prs: } \underbrace{\llbracket \phi \rrbracket = 1 \rightarrow \llbracket \text{EXH}^{st} \phi \rrbracket = 1}_{\text{exhaustivity}} \wedge \underbrace{[\exists \psi \in C . \llbracket \psi \rrbracket = 1]}_{\text{existence}} \\ \text{asr: } \llbracket \phi \rrbracket \end{cases}
 \end{aligned}$$

$$(19) \quad \llbracket \text{EXH}^{st} \rrbracket^w(C)(p) = 1 \text{ iff } p(w) = 1 \wedge \forall q \in C[p \not\subseteq q \rightarrow q(w) = 0]$$

The component of the semantics for the *[-i]* operator marked as *exhaustivity* is adopted from Fox (2020), who formulated exhaustivity in this conditional form, inspired by ideas in Büring & Križ (2013). What is marked as *existence* encodes the existence presupposition of clefts. Without this existence presupposition, it would not be possible to explain why *It’s not*

4. One could adopt more sophisticated meanings for EXH, for instance, one that is sensitive to Innocent Exclusion (Fox 2007), but it does not matter for my purposes; so I have kept it as simple as possible.

5. Sometimes, I will restate trivalent meanings as the combination of the resulting presupposition (“prs”) and the assertion (“asr”), to make the semantics easy to understand. But I am not formally adopting a two-dimensional treatment of presuppositions.

John that we invited presupposes *We invited someone*, because the exhaustivity presupposition (*If we invited John, then we invited only John*) does not entail *We invited someone*. Having this existence presupposition built into the meaning of *[-i]* is one place where I diverge from Doron (2025). In his implementation, the exhaustifying operator — which, following Bassi et al. (2021), he calls *PEX* — is defined to have only the component in its presupposition that is marked in (18) as *exhaustivity* (*ibid.*, (10): 107). This is because he was not concerned with the semantics of clefts *per se*. However, here, because of the Bangla data, *PEX* is fully identified with the focus operator that leads to cleft semantics. Since clefts come with an existence presupposition that at least one of the alternatives of the prejacent is true, the existence presupposition should be built into the meaning of *[-i]* as well. Another difference between my proposal and Doron’s (2025) is that, for him, both indefinites and definites are parsed with an exhaustifying operator in the restrictor, the difference between them arising from which object in its prejacent it focus-associates with (*ibid.*: 109). Such an analysis of the definite v. indefinite distinction does not help us explain the data in (1), where the overt presence of *[-i]* makes a crucial difference in determining whether a DP is definite or indefinite.

Before getting to (16b) itself, let us look at a cleft like (6b), the schema for which is given in (20a). In this case *[-i]* first attaches to *Amol* and, in narrow syntax, it moves to a position where it can have the whole sentence as its sister. At PF, the higher copy is deleted, and, at LF, the lower copy is deleted. When the higher copy is interpreted at LF, it takes the whole sentence as its prejacent, and the meaning comes out in accordance with the semantics given in (18). In the truth condition, the prejacent is asserted and exhaustified. In the falsity condition, the prejacent is negated, but the truth of at least one other alternative is asserted. When the disjunction of these two conditions are taken, it turns out to be *Someone came, and either Amol did not come or only Amol came*. Because of *modus tollens*, this is equivalent to the conditional presupposition *Someone came and if Amol came, then only Amol came*.

- (20) a. Amol-*[-i]* came.
 b. $\llbracket [-i \text{ [Amol came]}] \rrbracket$
 $= \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if Amol came and no one else came} \\ 0 & \text{if Amol did not come and at least someone came} \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$

Just as *[-i]* takes the denotation of the entire sentence as its argument in (20), *[-i]* takes the denotation of the sentence containing the indefinite DP, in the case of the LF in (16b). The result is completely parallel to the one shown in (20b). Since, after *[-i]* moves to take scope, the DP it moves away from is indefinite, the resulting reading behaves like an indefinite, explaining the behavior seen in (5). The resulting meanings, depending on the choice of the focus associate, are laid out in (21).

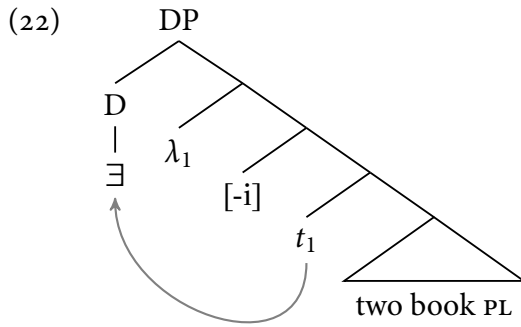
(21) a. **If the moved [-i] associates with two:**

$$\llbracket (16b) \rrbracket = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if the speaker read exactly two books} \\ 0 & \text{if there is at least one number } n \text{ such that the speaker has read } n \text{ books} \\ & \text{and the speaker has not read two books} \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

b. **If the moved [-i] associates with books:**

$$\llbracket (16b) \rrbracket = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if the speaker read two books and not any other two things} \\ 0 & \text{if there is at least one } P_{et} \text{ such that the speaker has read two entities in } P \\ & \text{and the speaker has not read two books} \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Now to the LF in (16c). (16c) is, in fact, a simplified LF. A more expanded LF needs to be given. (22) is this expanded DP structure. Here, crucially, the indefinite determiner has moved, leaving a trace of type e . When this trace combines with the $\langle e, t \rangle$ -type function denoted by “two book PL”, the result is a t -type node that $[-i]$ can combine with.⁶ Now, $[-i]$ can associate with the trace of the moved determiner, just as it associates with *Amol* in (20b).



Now it becomes possible to fully flesh out the meaning of the restrictor of the indefinite determiner, as in (23). The meaning of the prejacent is $[-i]$ is assignment-dependent. Thus, assuming the unmodified assignment function is g , the result of applying $[-i]$ to its sister is that, when true, $g(1)$ is the only sum of two books. This can be true only when there are exactly two books. When false, $g(1)$ is not a sum of two books and there is at least one entity which is a sum of two books. The “ $\exists Z . Z$ is a sum of two books” part of the conditions is rewritten as $\Pi \exists$. In the truth condition, it is already entailed by the part without it, unlike in the falsity condition; but it is still put in parentheses as a reminder that it is there.

6. This is also the kind of structure assumed in Doron (2025). Also see chapter 7 of Hirsch (2017) for a discussion of why such a structure of DPs might be conceptually appealing.

$$\begin{aligned}
 (23) \quad & \llbracket [\lambda_1 [-i^{st} [t_1 [\text{two book-PL}]]]] \rrbracket \\
 & = \lambda X_e . \left\{ \begin{array}{ll} 1 & \text{if } X \text{ is a sum of books} \\ & \wedge \forall Y [Y \text{ is a sum of books} \rightarrow Y \sqsubseteq X] \wedge |X| = 2 \\ & (\wedge \exists Z . Z \text{ is a sum of two books}) \\ 0 & \text{if } X \text{ is not a sum of books} \vee |X| \neq 2 \\ & \wedge \exists Z . Z \text{ is a sum of two books} \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{array} \right. \\
 & = \lambda X_e . \left\{ \begin{array}{ll} 1 & \text{if } X \text{ is a sum of books} \\ & \wedge \forall Y [Y \text{ is a sum of books} \rightarrow Y \sqsubseteq X] \wedge |X| = 2 \\ & (\wedge \Pi_{\exists}) \\ 0 & \text{if } X \text{ is not a sum of books} \vee |X| \neq 2 \\ & \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{array} \right.
 \end{aligned}$$

This can be rewritten as the predicate expanded in (24), where “prs” stands for the disjunction of the truth and falsity conditions in (23), and “asr” stands for the assertoric component. Since $\Pi_{\exists}$ is entailed by both the truth and falsity conditions, it is shown as a separate conjunct in the entire presupposition.

$$\begin{aligned}
 (24) \quad & \lambda X_e . \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{prs: } ((X \text{ is not a sum of books} \vee |X| \neq 2) \\ \quad \vee (X \text{ is a sum of books} \wedge \forall Y [Y \text{ is a sum of books} \rightarrow Y \sqsubseteq X] \wedge |X| = 2)) \\ \quad \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \\ \equiv (\neg(X \text{ is not a sum of books} \vee |X| \neq 2) \\ \quad \rightarrow (X \text{ is a sum of books} \wedge \forall Y [Y \text{ is a sum of books} \rightarrow Y \sqsubseteq X] \wedge |X| = 2)) \\ \quad \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \\ \equiv (X \text{ is a sum of books and } |X| = 2 \\ \quad \rightarrow (X \text{ is a sum of books} \wedge \forall Y [Y \text{ is a sum of books} \rightarrow Y \sqsubseteq X] \wedge |X| = 2)) \\ \quad \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \\ \equiv (\text{if } X \text{ is a sum of two books, then } X \text{ is the maximal sum of two books}) \\ \quad \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \\ \equiv \underbrace{\varepsilon(X)}_{\text{exhaustivity}} \wedge \underbrace{\Pi_{\exists}}_{\text{existence}} \quad (\text{rewriting the first conjunct as “}\varepsilon(X)\text{”}) \\ \text{asr: } X \text{ is a sum of two books} \end{array} \right.
 \end{aligned}$$

That is, both the truth condition and falsity condition of the restrictor of the indefinite entail existence of at least one entity which is a sum of two books, *i.e.*, $\Pi_{\exists}$. As I will argue below, this is the source of the existence presupposition of definites.

At this point, the restrictor of the indefinite is trivalent, that is, it has a presupposition. This presupposition, as shown in the last line of (24), has two components: exhaustivity, written as “ $\varepsilon(X)$ ”, and existence, written as “ $\Pi_{\exists}$ ”. I will now assume that this presupposition projects to the matrix level according to a Strong Kleene schema of presupposition projection, given in (25), for an existential quantification structure whose restrictor is trivalent.

The subscripted π is supposed to indicate that the predicate P comes with the presupposition π . That is, π is the conjunction of the exhaustivity statement and the existence statement derived in the expanded “prs” in (24), P is the “asr” part, and Q is the nuclear scope.

$$(25) \quad \exists x[P_\pi(x) \wedge Q(x)] \rightsquigarrow \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } \exists x[\pi(x) \wedge P_\pi(x) \wedge Q(x)] \\ 0 & \text{if } \forall x[\neg Q(x) \vee [\pi(x) \wedge \neg P_\pi(x)]] \\ \# & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Rewriting π as the conjunction of the exhaustivity statement and the existence statement, the truth and falsity conditions for (16c) can be arrived at as shown in (26). In the case of the truth condition, the existence statement contains no bound variables. Therefore, it can be moved out of the scope of the existential quantifier. For ease of reading, parts of the prose and their corresponding parts in the formulas are colored the same during the transition from formulas to prose.

- (26) a. **Truth condition of (16c):**
 $\exists x[\pi(x) \wedge P_\pi(x) \wedge Q(x)]$
 $\equiv \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi\exists \wedge P_\pi(x) \wedge Q(x)]$
 $\equiv \Pi\exists \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_\pi(x) \wedge Q(x)]$
 $\equiv$ There is at least one sum of two books
 $\quad \wedge \exists x[\text{if } x \text{ is a sum of two books, then it is the maximal sum of two books}$
 $\quad \wedge x \text{ is a sum of two books} \wedge \text{the speaker read } x]$
 $\equiv$ There is at least one sum of two books
 $\quad \wedge \exists x[x \text{ is the maximal sum of two books} \wedge \text{the speaker read } x]$
 $\equiv$ The entity that is a sum of two books is the maximal sum of two books
 and has been read by the speaker.
- b. **Falsity condition of (16c):**
 $\forall x[\neg Q(x) \vee [\pi(x) \wedge \neg P_\pi(x)]]$
 $\equiv \forall x[\neg Q(x) \vee [\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi\exists \wedge \neg P_\pi(x)]]$
 $\equiv$ Everything x is such that x is either not read by the speaker, or there is
 at least one sum of two books, x is not a sum of two books, and if x
 is a sum of two books, then x is the maximal sum of two books
 $\equiv$ Everything x is such that x is either not read by the speaker, or there is
 at least one sum of two books, x is not a sum of two books, and if x is a
 sum of two books, then x is the maximal sum of two books
 $\equiv$ Everything x is such that x is either not read by the speaker, or there is at
 least one sum of two books and x is not a sum of two books
 (because the conditional is vacuously true
 if x is not a sum of two books)
- c. **Presupposition of (16c):**
 the disjunction of (26a) and (26b)

$$\begin{aligned} &\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x) \wedge Q(x)]] \\ &\quad \vee \\ &\quad \forall x[\neg Q(x) \vee [\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]] \end{aligned}$$

According to the truth condition, in order for the LF in (16c) to be true, there needs to be a unique maximal sum of two books. This is consistent with what is perceived as the presupposition of a definite.

According to the falsity condition, there are two ways for the sentence to be false. One is when nothing has been read by the speaker. In case that is not true, another way for the sentence to be false is when the following holds: there is another unique (therefore, maximal) entity which is a sum of two books. Of these two ways, the latter is consistent with what is perceived as the presupposition of a definite, because it ensures the existence of a unique maximal sum of two books. However, the former way for the LF to be false is the source of the worry here, because it is possible for the speaker to have read nothing, while there is no entity that is a sum of two books. That is, the falsity condition in (26b) predicts that there are worlds where the LF in (16c) receives a classical truth value even if there is no entity that is a sum of two books.

To sum up the prediction, while the predicted truth condition explains the known profile of a definite description, the falsity condition does not, in that it fails to ensure existence. Given this prediction, what might seem to be a solution is to combine what I have developed in this subsection with an ι operator, identical to the one in (13), repeated below. This can be described as a hybrid account incorporating what I have developed in this section, and Coppock & Beaver's (2015) proposal about the ι operator. This hybrid account would predict existence even in negated sentences with definites, as desired.

$$(13) \quad \llbracket \iota \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . 1 \text{ if there is a unique } x \text{ such that } P(x) = 1; \text{ undefined otherwise}$$

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (84), (86): 408; rephrased for my purposes)

Nevertheless, I will pursue an alternative account without any ι operator, because such an account would extend to cases such as (11) (*Scott is (not) the only author of Waverley*) and (15) (*the rabbit in the hat*). Later in section 6, I will point out why such a hybrid account is not fully adequate for these cases. For now, I would like to ask the reader to put a pin on this and bear with me seeking an alternative to ι . This, I do in the next subsection.

5.2 Incrementalization

It turns out that there is more to be said about the final presupposition of the LF in (16c), which has to do with the asymmetric nature of presupposition projection. To put this in perspective with a basic case, consider (27). Let us begin with the good case, (27a). Here, the first conjunct entails the presupposition of the second; therefore, whenever the first conjunct is false, the whole conjunction receives the third truth value #. But this # value of the second conjunct ends up not mattering because the first conjunct being false necessarily means

that the whole conjunction will be false. In other words, a sentence of the form $\lceil p \wedge S_p \rceil$ (where A_B stands for an atomic proposition A with the presupposition B) does not presuppose anything. More generally, a sentence of the form $\lceil S_1 \wedge S_p \rceil$ does not presuppose anything, provided S_1 entails p and presupposes nothing. This follows from saying that a conjunction of the form $\lceil S_1 \wedge S_p \rceil$ presupposes the material implication $S_1 \rightarrow p$, when S_1 presupposes nothing.

- (27) a. Moldavia has a king and the king of Moldavia is bald.
 b. #The king of Moldavia is bald, and Moldavia has a king.

The problem is that this way of talking about presuppositions does not make any reference to linear order, which (27b) is obviously sensitive to. In exactly this context, it has been pointed out by Fox (2008), based on the notion of incrementalization developed in Schlenker (2008), that the behavior of (27b) (let us schematize this as $\lceil S_p \wedge S_1 \rceil$) can be predicted by incrementalizing the global presupposition $S_1 \rightarrow p$. For the purposes of this paper, I adopt the way incrementalization has been conceptualized in Fox (2008).⁷ An incrementalized presupposition of (27b) right after *and* has been pronounced, before the pronunciation of the second conjunct, is the presupposition of the whole sentence, no matter what comes after. The notion of “what comes after” can be formalized as that of *good finals* (terminology from Schlenker 2008) as in (28).

(28) **Good final**

Let ϕ dominate α . Let $\mathcal{GF}(\phi, \alpha)$ be the set of good finals of ϕ computed at α .

$\mathcal{GF}(\phi, \alpha) = \{\phi' : \phi' \text{ can be derived from } \phi \text{ by replacing what } \alpha \text{ precedes with objects of the same syntactic category}\}$

When this definition is applied to the case of (27b), it amounts to saying that the presupposition of (27b) is $S_1 \rightarrow p$, no matter which member of $\mathcal{GF}(S_p \wedge S_1, S_p)$ replaces S_1 . This, in turn, is the same as saying the presupposition is simply p , because of the equivalence in (29). This explains why (27b) is infelicitous when it is not known in the context whether Moldavia has a king.

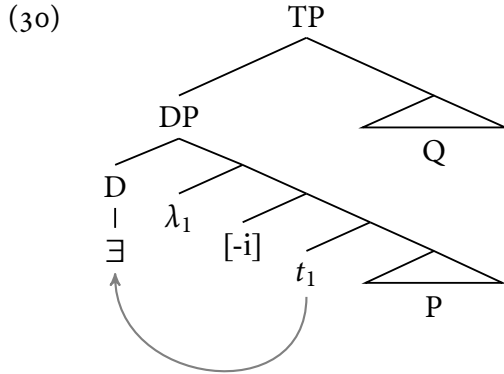
$$(29) \quad \forall \phi [\phi \rightarrow \psi] \equiv \psi$$

The interesting thing is that, when this notion of incrementalization is applied to the presupposition in (26c), a reasonable way to extend the current notion of good finals to include quantificational structures yields an incrementalized version of (26c) that entails the existence presupposition, despite what the falsity condition in (26b) leads us to believe. I explain this immediately below.⁸

7. Also see George (2008b) for a similar idea.

8. The contribution of incrementalization here is owed to a discussion with Danny Fox (p.c.).

Recall that the LF in question is (16c). This LF can be schematized as (30), where P abbreviates the restrictor (prior to the application of $[-i]$) and Q abbreviates the nuclear scope in the object language.



At the point in semantic composition where the indefinite determiner has combined with just its restrictor, incrementalization kicks in. This is completely parallel to how incrementalization worked for (27b): in (27b), the part of the sentence that was “disregarded” for the purposes of incrementalization was the part that exactly followed the conjunct triggering the presupposition. Similarly, it now makes sense to incrementalize the presupposition in (26c), by “disregarding” what is introduced into semantic composition right after the indefinite combines with its restrictor. Incrementalizing the presupposition at this point of evaluation would mean that the sentence as a whole would have to satisfy the predicted presupposition, no matter what follows P , that is, no matter what Q stands for. This explains the intuition that, upon hearing sentences like *The book is red* in English, the uniqueness/maximality inferences are made as soon as the phrase *the book* is heard, regardless of what the nuclear scope is.

However, it should be clarified at this point how to formally think about of this incrementalization in the case of quantificational structures in general, because not all sentences with definites have the definite in a non-final position, in English, e.g., *John read the book*. One might think that the issue of incrementalization becomes moot here for the same reason it does in cases like (27a) ($\lceil S_1 \wedge S_p \rceil$), that is, simply because the presupposition trigger (*the book*) linearly follows the material that counts as nuclear scope (*John read*), and there are no good finals to be quantified over once *the book* has been pronounced. However, assuming a definite is analyzed as an indefinite with an exhaustified restrictor, it is only at the end of the sentence that it becomes clear that we are dealing with a parse like (30), where *the book* has QRed from the object position (not shown in (30)). That is, the notion of good finals now needs to be sensitive to the fact that there can be multiple occurrences of the same phrase in a parse due to movement. This can be done by building the possibility of multiple occurrences into the notion of precedence as in (31). This notion of precedence is not considered or developed in Fox (2008), Schlenker (2008).

(31) **Precedence**

α precedes β iff at least one occurrence of α precedes at least one occurrence of β .

Now, when a set of good finals is computed based on this notion of precedence and the original definition of good finals in (28), the net result is that, upon the pronunciation of *the book* in *John read the book*, the set of good finals for (30) at the point of *P* must be computed with *Q*, the nuclear scope, being included in what follows *P*, despite the fact that *the book*, sitting in the object position, linearly follows the nuclear scope. This is because, although the lower, pronounced copy of *the book* is at the very end of the sentence, there is at least one copy of it that precedes the nuclear scope — the higher, unpronounced copy. Therefore, according to (31), *Q* in (30) is to be included into what follows *P*. As a result, there should be no difference in how incrementalization works in a sentence with a definite in a sentence-non-final position and a sentence with a definite in a sentence-final position.

So, now, incrementalization is to be computed exactly as in the case of (27b). The set of good finals here is the set of various objects of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ that can serve as the nuclear scope of an indefinite. If we now look back at the presupposition in (26c), the result of *Q* being irrelevant pans out as follows. One easy way to think about what incrementalization does at a given point in a parse is to think of the process as making the presupposition of the whole sentence strong enough, so that it is met regardless of what comes after that point. That is, if the presupposition in (26c) is to be incrementalized at the point where the determiner has just merged with its restrictor, then that is the same as making this presupposition strong enough, so that it is met regardless of what the nuclear scope is. Now, it just so happens that this strengthened presupposition is what is obtained by replacing *Q* in the formula with the tautological predicate ($\top$), because such a replacement makes the contribution of *Q* not matter for the whole presupposition. The result of this replacement is shown step by step in (32b).

(32) a. **Presupposition before incrementalization, repeated from (26c):**

$$[\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x) \wedge Q(x)]] \vee \forall x[\neg Q(x) \vee [\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]]$$

b. **Replacing *Q* with $\top$:**

$$[\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x) \wedge \top(x)]] \vee \forall x[\neg \top(x) \vee [\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]]$$

$$\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee \forall x[\perp(x) \vee [\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]]$$

(assuming “ $\perp$ ” stands for the contradictory predicate)

$$\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee \forall x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]$$

$$\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee \forall x[\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \neg P_{\pi}(x)]$$

(because $\varepsilon(x)$ expresses a conditional whose antecedent is negated by $\neg P_{\pi}(x)$, making the whole conditional vacuously true)

$$\begin{aligned}
 &\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \forall x[\neg P_{\pi}(x)]] \\
 &\quad \text{(since } \Pi_{\exists} \text{ does not contain bound variables)} \\
 &\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee [\exists x[P_{\pi}(x)] \wedge \forall x[\neg P_{\pi}(x)]] \\
 &\quad \text{(since } \Pi_{\exists} \text{ stands for the existence of at least one sum of two books)} \\
 &\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee [\exists x[P_{\pi}(x)] \wedge \neg \exists x[P_{\pi}(x)]] \\
 &\quad \text{(since } \forall x\neg\phi(x) \equiv \neg\exists x\phi(x)) \\
 &\equiv [\Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)]] \vee \perp \\
 &\equiv \Pi_{\exists} \wedge \exists x[\varepsilon(x) \wedge P_{\pi}(x)] \\
 &\equiv \text{There is a unique/maximal sum of two books.}
 \end{aligned}$$

The result of this incrementalization is precisely existence and uniqueness/maximality. The effect we are seeing here is completely parallel to the effect seen in (27b), where the presupposition of the whole sentence was strengthened from $S_1 \rightarrow p$, due to the irrelevance of the second conjunct. This is desirable, since negated sentences with definites come with the same existence and uniqueness/maximality presuppositions that affirmative ones do.

5.3 The difference between the two Bangla definites

The previous subsection focused on how $[-i]$ can, in general, combine with the restrictor of an indefinite to yield the definite reading. That is, it gives a compositional account of (1c). But we still need to understand how (1b) differs from (1c). This is because both behave as definites, as seen in section 2. This is what I will turn to now.

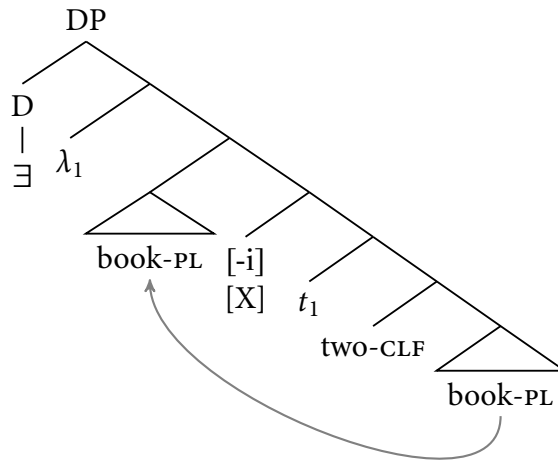
I would propose to think of the difference between (1b) and (1c) as follows. Definiteness always arises through the contribution of the cleft morpheme $[-i]$, which is introduced into the nominal spine as a head, above the classifier. However, it must be silent if an overt NP is pronounced in its specifier (much in the vein of the Doubly Filled Comp Filter)⁹. The $[-i]$ morpheme can be optionally endowed with a feature that attracts and moves the NP inside the DP into its specifier. I would like to remain agnostic about what feature exactly this is. Let us call this $[X]$ for the purposes of this paper.

If this $[X]$ feature is present in $[-i]$, the NP moves past the classifier to the specifier of $[-i]$, yielding the noun-first linear order in (1b). Because of the rule governing when $[-i]$ can or cannot be pronounced, in this case, it is silent. This is shown in the derivation in (33a). If the $[X]$ feature is absent in $[-i]$, then the NP fails to move, remains *in situ*, and because nothing is pronounced in the specifier of $[-i]$, it itself is pronounced, yielding the linear order in (1c).

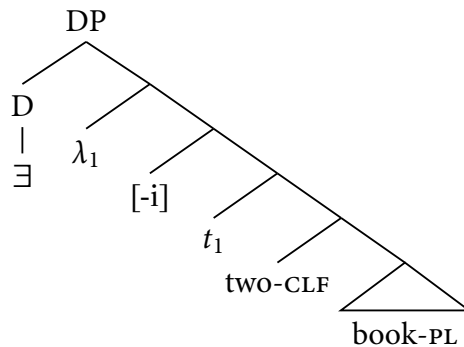
9. The analogy with the Doubly Filled Comp Filter is owed to David Pesetsky (p.c.).

This is shown in the derivation in (33b). The presence of $[-i]$ in both derivations ensures that both of these DPs are definite.

- (33) a. *Derivation for the noun-first DP, without $[-i]$, (1b):*



- b. *Derivation for the numeral-first DP, with $[-i]$, (1c):*



Thus, the account of definiteness I am advocating here is directly tied to the linear order alternation seen in (1).

6 Relationship with prior compositional accounts of definiteness

The gist of the account presented in section 5 is that definites contain two components in their meaning: one of indefiniteness and another leading to the uniqueness/maximality presupposition. As discussed in section 3, this compositional idea is not new. It has been pursued before in Bumford (2017a,b, 2018), Coppock & Beaver (2012a,b, 2014, 2015). I have already discussed why it is not obvious how to think of data like (1) within these accounts:

because they do not explicitly tie the meaning of definiteness to a focus-sensitive exhaustification operator like the *[-i]* morpheme of Bangla. In this section, I will point out what insight the approach I am advocating here brings to the facts that originally lead these other strands of compositional accounts.

Let us begin with (11), repeated below, which was Coppock & Beaver’s (2015) starting point. As discussed in section 3, their account interprets *only* inside the DP in the problematic cases, *i.e.*, (11b). For them, the reason the expression *the only author of Waverley* is acceptable in (11b) is the “ $|P| \leq 1$ ” part in the meaning of *the* they assume, repeated below, which ensures the possibility of the restrictor of the definite to denote an empty set.

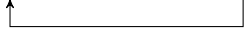
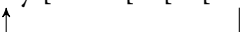
- (11) a. **Context:**
 The speaker is in the world we live in, where Scott is the only author of *Waverley*.
 Scott is the only author of *Waverley*. [1 author]
- b. **Context:**
 The speaker is in a world different from ours, where someone co-authored *Waverley* with Scott.
 Scott is not the only author of *Waverley*. [> 1 author]

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (2): 380)

$$(12) \llbracket \text{the} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \lambda x_e : |P| \leq 1 . P(x) = 1$$

(Coppock & Beaver 2015, (50): 395; notation modified)

From the perspective of my account, however, (11b) is accounted for by moving the exhaustifying operator out of the DP (just as *[-i]* is moved to the matrix level in (6b)). In the case of (11), this operator is *only*. That is, *only* plays a role similar to that played by *[-i]* in Bangla. Once *only* is thought of in this way, it becomes possible to posit movement of *only* out of the DP, as in (34). At PF, the higher copy of *only* can be deleted, and at LF, the lower one can be deleted. Then, for PF, a spell-out rule can be written to the effect that $\exists$ is pronounced as *the*, when followed by *only*, regardless of where *only* is interpreted at LF. (As before, “ $\exists$ ” stands for the existential determiner head in the object language.)

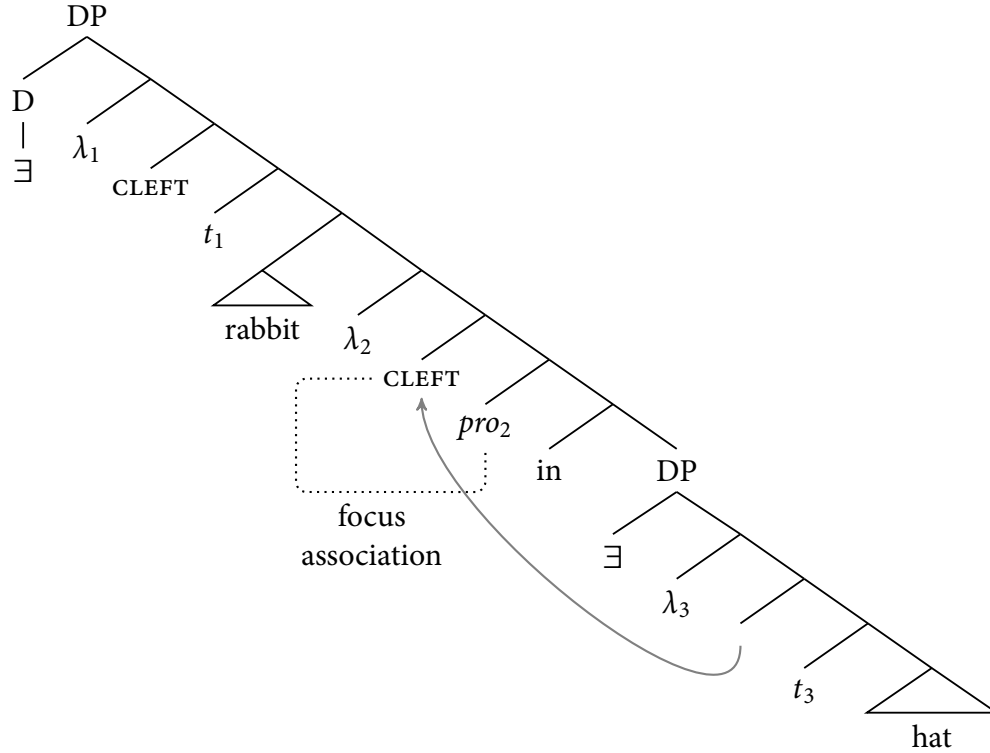
- (34) a. **LF for (11a); ignoring QR of the indefinite:**
 [only [Scott [is [$\exists$ [only [author of *Waverley*]]]]]]

 $\rightsquigarrow$ Scott is an author of *Waverley* and no one else is.
- b. **LF for (11b); ignoring QR of the indefinite:**
 [not [only [Scott [is [$\exists$ [only [author of *Waverley*]]]]]]]

 $\rightsquigarrow$ It is not the case that Scott is an author of *Waverley* and no one else is.

Crucially, in (34b), once *only* has moved out of the DP, the DP is an indefinite (*author of Waverley*), without any existence or uniqueness/maximality inference. Therefore, it behaves exactly as an indefinite like *author of Waverley* is otherwise expected to be in the scope of negation in (11b). In this respect, my account of the acceptability of (11b) has the same logic as in Heim's (1999) operator movement account of the relative-absolute ambiguity of superlatives (Heim 1999, Sharvit 2015, Sharvit & Stateva 2002, Szabolcsi 1986, a.o.) and the *only*-movement account in Sharvit (2015). In fact, this is identical to Sharvit's (2015) approach. So, I am not saying anything new here; rather, I am pointing out that this movement approach fits perfectly with the account I am developing here. The idea that (11) can be analyzed in this way is also in Bumford (2017b).

Consider also, in this context, the hybrid account mentioned at the end of subsection 5.1, combining the proposal developed in that section and the ι operator. Under such an account, *only* would move to take matrix scope, just as in (34), but the ι operator would remain down below, inside the DP, triggering the presupposition of existence and uniqueness. In the case of (11b), this would lead to presupposition failure, because there is no unique author of *Waverley*. This is same as the issue in Heim (1999), Szabolcsi (1986), a.o., all over again — that of deleting the definite determiner and replacing it with an indefinite when operator movement takes place (which, in their cases, is the movement of the superlative morpheme *-est*). Coppock & Beaver's (2015) original proposal took care of this by defining *the* as in (12), which does not presuppose existence. But, as I have argued in section 3, their account misses the connection with clefts, which section 5.1 is an attempt to improve upon. This means that the route to existence from the meaning derived in section 5.1 is better thought of as incrementalization, as described in section 5.2, than something as simple as adding an extra operator to the structure.

Moving on to Bumford's account, recall that his decompositional account involves analyzing a definite as the combination of an indefinite and a test introduced later to make sure that the same entity is assigned to the discourse referent introduced by the indefinite. Part of his motivation for adopting this test-based analysis of definites is cases like (15) (*the rabbit in the hat*). In his system, the test helps account for the felicity of definites like this (in the relevant context described above (15)) because the delayed introduction of the test for *hat* allows for additional information about rabbits to be included in the description.

Under my account, however, cases like this can also be subsumed under the moving of the exhaustifying operator. This is shown in (35) for the expression *the rabbit in the hat* (interpreted felicitously when there is only one rabbit-containing hat, regardless of how many hats there are). Specifically, I will propose that, in English, CLEFT is a silent version of the Bangla [-i]. In (35), the modifier *in the hat* has been analyzed as a reduced relative of sorts. So, inside this modifier, there is a null pronoun *pro*₂ (or a trace, depending on the analysis of reduced relatives). This pronoun combines with *in the hat* as the subject of the latter.

(35) *Derivation for (15a):*


Crucially, now, there are two derivational options: CLEFT can either remain inside *the hat* (like (16c)) or it can move to take scope at a propositional node (like (16b)). The former option results in a uniqueness/maximality presupposition. So, even if this LF (not shown here) is accessed, it is infelicitous in a context where there are multiple hats but only one rabbit-containing hat. The latter option is the one shown in (35). This LF does not require the existence of a unique/maximal hat, simply because CLEFT is just not in the right position for this effect to arise through presupposition projection. Instead, what this LF can be paraphrased as is the following: *the rabbit such that it is the only rabbit in a hat*. This meaning arises precisely because CLEFT associates with the pronoun from its moved position and yields the meaning that nothing else is in a hat. Furthermore, because CLEFT has moved out of the DP, the simple existential force of it remains, allowing *the hat* to be interpreted basically as *a hat*. The entire DP, however, comes with a uniqueness/maximality presupposition, because of the CLEFT operator merged above *rabbit* — unless this CLEFT, too, interacts with the rest of the sentence through movement,¹⁰ just like the lower CLEFT. This explains why

10. For instance, *John adopted the rabbit in the hat* is felicitous where John adopts a hat-contained rabbit — among rabbits contained in things that are not hats — while Bill adopts a rabbit in a bag, and Sue adopts a rabbit in a sock. The paraphrase of the relevant LF here is: *John is the only individual who adopted a rabbit in a hat*. Here, both of the definite determiners are interpreted as indefinites, because CLEFT has moved away from both of them.

there must be only one rabbit-containing hat.^{11, 12}

Consider again how the hybrid account described at the end of subsection 5.1 would fare in these cases of definites embedded in definites. Even after the CLEFT operator has moved out, the *ι* operator would remain inside the DP corresponding to *the hat*, leading to the uniqueness presupposition for hats, which would fail, because there are multiple hats in the context of interest. That is, the hybrid account does not work for cases like (15a) for the same reason it does not work for (11).

This movement-based way of thinking about definite descriptions like *the rabbit in the hat* fills a small hole in Bumford's account, which he acknowledges. As Bumford (2017a) notes, while the introduction of the test for uniqueness/maximality can be delayed until

11. This, of course, raises the question of why the same behavior is not observed with the expression *the rabbit in the only hat*, because, assuming a Sharvit-style *only* movement I am adopting here, the denotation of this expression should be paraphrasable as *the rabbit such that it is the only rabbit in a hat*. I do not have a solution for this at the moment. However, as pointed out to me by Danny Fox (p.c.), this difference between *only* and CLEFT is reminiscent of the literature on how focus-sensitive operators differ from each other in what they can or cannot associate with and how they associate with their foci, e.g., Beaver & Clark (2003, 2008). One possibility, therefore, would be to investigate possible differences between *only* and CLEFT in a similar way. This is not to fully endorse every aspect of the cited literature or to say that the split they propose among various focus-sensitive operators applies exactly to the case at hand. I mention them as a proof of concept that the mechanisms behind focus-sensitivity might be relevant. I will leave a fuller exploration of this to a future occasion.

12. If this is indeed the correct account of Haddock's cases, then the question arises of why it is apparently not possible for *I saw the man* to mean *Only I saw a man*. For reasons of space, I would only briefly point out such readings are indeed available, once the right context is provided. For instance, consider (i). The sentence is acceptable in the given context, which can be made more palpable by putting focus on *John*. Given my account of Haddock's cases, the felicity of the definite description *the red ball* in (i) in the given context, despite there being multiple red balls, can be explained by the movement of the CLEFT operator (or the overt *only*) out of *the red ball*, leaving the indefinite part of the meaning downstairs, and subsequent focus-association with *John* from the moved position. Although, on the face of it, it seems that domain restriction is what is operative here in making the definite felicitous, domain restriction accounts do not extend to cases of binding by the subject into the definite DP, as in (ii). This point has been made at length in Bumford (2018), in the context of relative readings of superlatives, which can be extended to cover (ii). The interested reader is referred to Bumford (2018) on this issue. Also see footnote 10.

- (i) JOHN picked the (only) red ball.

Possible context:

There are some blue balls, red balls, and green balls in a jar. There are multiple balls of each color. As part of a game, John, Mary, and Bill put their hands in the jar and draw a ball without seeing which color they picked. So, it's up to chance what color they get and the idea is that depending on who gets which color, certain decisions in the game will be made. John gets red, Mary and Bill both get green.

- (ii) **Context:**

John, Mary, and Bill pick out books from the library to read. The mother of each is an author and their books are at the library they go to. John picks out a book written by his own mother, but Mary and Bill don't: they also pick out books written by John's mother. So, every book that is taken out is written by John's mother. There are other books written by their mothers in the library.

JOHN₁ took out the book written by his₁ mother. (Mary and Bill didn't.)

Intended: John is the only individual *x* such that *x* took out a book by *x*'s mother.

rabbit is introduced in the structure in (15a), there are constraints on how much distance can separate the test and the indefinite part of the meaning of a definite. For instance, they cannot be separated by an island boundary, as shown in (36b), which features an adjunct island.

- (36) a. **Context:**
 There is only one gum that has a balloon sticking to it. There are other balloons that are not sticking to gums.
 I'm looking for the gum sticking to the balloon.
- b. **Context:**
 There is only one gum that fell after sticking to a balloon. There are other balloons such that there are gums that have fallen after sticking to them.
 #I'm looking for the gum that fell after sticking to the balloon.

(Bumford 2017a, (12): 558)

Within Bumford's account, although one could, in theory, come up with some sort of constraint on the distribution of tests, there is, in principle, no reason for such a constraint to exist. In the movement-based approach advocated here, nothing additional needs to be said for these cases, because, since the target meanings are the result of the exhaustifying operator moving, the usual island constraints on movement should be applicable in these cases as well, thus ruling out (36b). This is parallel to the island-sensitivity of *[-i]*-movement in the Bangla cases in (17).

7 Conclusion and remaining issues

I have tried to show in this paper that a previously unexplored paradigm in the definite-indefinite alternation in Bangla DPs brings a new insight into the debate on how the meaning of definiteness is composed in general, specifically, those that break it up into an existential meaning and a uniqueness/maximality meaning. The existing approaches along this line do not fully articulate the link between the uniqueness/maximality part of the meaning of definites to the meaning of exhaustivity found in clefts. This link becomes fully visible in Bangla, where an otherwise indefinite DP gains the option to be interpreted as a definite when a cleft morpheme is attached inside the DP. The existing approaches cannot satisfactorily shed light on the Bangla data, given they do not exploit the cleft-definiteness link to the farthest possible extent.

Before ending this paper, I will address three remaining issues. First, given all the Bangla data discussed here, the reader would be right to wonder what this system predicts when the numeral is one and whether that prediction is borne out. Let us see the prediction first. I will then then characterize it appropriately, and see if the corresponding Bangla sentence meets those characterizations.

So, the new LF that now has to be considered is in (37).

(37) $[[\exists [-i^{st} [\text{one book SG}]]] \lambda_1 \text{ I read } t_1]$

For the exact same reasons as in the case of (16c), this LF also results in a uniqueness/maximality presupposition. That is, in a parallel fashion to the last line in (32b), the predicted presupposition for this sentence is *There exists a unique book*.

So, here is our prediction for sentences with the numeral one: when there is just one book, the definite reading of the numeral-first $[-i]$ DP should be available. This is not a good prediction because, in (38b), $[\text{æk-}t\text{a} \text{ nak-e-}\tilde{i}]$ “one-CLF nose-LOC-FOC” is infelicitous. This can only be made sense of if this DP fails to convey the meaning of a definite, and loses to the singular definite $[\text{nak-}t\text{a}]$ “nose-CLF” in competition (see discussion on (39) immediately below). That is, (38b), $[\text{æk-}t\text{a} \text{ nak-e-}\tilde{i}]$ “one-CLF nose-LOC-FOC”, despite the presence of the cleft morpheme, fails to gain the option to be interpreted as a definite, unlike DPs with bigger numerals.

- (38) a. #ama-r **æk-ta** **nak-e** $g^{\tilde{h}}\tilde{u}fi$ $k^h\text{e-et}^h\text{-i}$.
 1.SG-GEN **one-CLF** **nose-LOC** punch eat-PERF-PRS.1
 #“I got punched in a nose of mine.”
- b. #ama-r **æk-ta** **nak-e-}\tilde{i}** $g^{\tilde{h}}\tilde{u}fi$ $k^h\text{e-et}^h\text{-i}$.
 1.SG-GEN **one-CLF** **nose-LOC-FOC** punch eat-PERF-PRS.1
 Intended but unavailable reading that would have been felicitous:
 “I got punched in my nose.”

Although, in this respect, I make a problematic prediction, there are reasons to believe that, while I can successfully account for the plural cases, what happens in singular DPs with a numeral is an uncharted territory to begin with. This is because, while switching the order between the numeral and NP changes the DP’s (in)definiteness property (see (1)), the same is not true for $[\text{æk-}t\text{a}/\text{-}\tilde{c}on \text{ NP}]$ “one-CLF NP”. In fact, in this case, only the numeral-first order is acceptable, and the noun-first order is simply impossible, as shown in (39). If the definite singular meaning is intended, one must drop the numeral altogether and say (39c).

- (39) a. ami **æk-ta** **boi} $po\text{t-et}^h\text{-i}$.
 1.SG.NOM **one-CLF** **book** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “I’ve read a book.”**
- b. *ami **boi} **æk-ta** $po\text{t-et}^h\text{-i}$.
 1.SG.NOM **book** **one-CLF** read-PERF-PRS.1
 Intended:
 “I’ve read the book.”**
- c. ami **boi-ta** $po\text{t-et}^h\text{-i}$.
 1.SG.NOM **book-CLF** read-PERF-PRS.1
 “I’ve read the book.”

This means that neither the DP-internal NP movement past the numeral nor the definite reading of numeral-first DPs with *[-i]* is observed when the numeral is one. One reason for this could be that *[æk-ta]* “one-CLF”, in Bangla, is not a numeral; instead it is a determiner, like the English *a(n)*. So, it is higher than the landing site of the moving NP in the DP, and therefore, the DP-internal movement is string-vacuous.

But this still does not explain why *[æk-ta nak-e-i]* “one-CLF nose-LOC-FOC” cannot have a definite reading, because it can still be parsed as (40), where “one-CLF” is the D^0 . There is no reason why *[-i]* should not behave here exactly as it does for bigger numerals.

(40) [DP [D^0 one-CLF] [NP $-i^{st}$ [NP nose SG]]]

I do not have a concrete idea about what a solution to this could be. However, here is my intuition. In English, DPs like *an only child* fails to receive a definite interpretation in any context, despite the presence of *only*, which is supposed to have some exhaustivizing property. The only way to have a definite interpretation is to say *the only child*. I believe something very similar is going on in the case of the Bangla (40). The generalization seems to be that the indefinite determiner cannot be overt in a DP that receives a definite interpretation. Why this should be the case is a different, independent topic, which I believe is demonstrated by cases like *an only child*. I would like to speculate that this pertains to the more general question of how a Sharvit-style *only*-movement analysis fits with non-definite exclusives like *an only child*. If this speculation has any merit, then a starting point for an inquiry along this line might be Herdan & Sharvit (2006), who explore similar data in English, but with non-definite superlatives, like *a smartest boy*.

The second remaining issue is the interaction between Bangla bare nouns (e.g., *[boi]* “book”) and *[-i]*. Firstly, as noted by Simpson & Biswas (2016), bare nouns in Bangla are ambiguous between an indefinite and a definite interpretation (and a number-neutral one, which can be ignored for my purposes here; *ibid.*, (3): 2).¹³ The indefinite reading of bare nouns can be relatively easily explained by positing a null indefinite determiner, which I have assumed for Bangla throughout the paper anyway. However, something additional has to be said about the definite reading of bare nouns in Bangla. Here is a preliminary answer to this. Bangla bare nouns are three-way structurally ambiguous, and it can be parsed as the three following ways:

- as a DP with a null indefinite determiner, but without an *[-i]* (let us call it the *true-bare* parse);
- as a DP with a null indefinite determiner and with an *[-i]* bearing the [X] feature (let us call it the *spec-bare* parse);

13. They further note that the definite usage of Bangla bare nouns, e.g., *[boi]* “book”, corresponds to what is known as the *weak/unique definite*, in the sense of Schwarz (2009), as opposed to the *strong/anaphoric definite*, which is expressed by bare nouns with a classifier, like *[boi-ta]* “book-CLF” (also see (39)). I refer the interested reader to their paper for those details.

- as a DP with a null indefinite determiner and with an $[-i]$ not bearing the $[X]$ feature (let us call it the *comp-bare* parse);

The true-bare parse is pronounced as simply the bare noun itself for obvious reasons. The spec-bare parse, because of the presence of the $[X]$ feature, will involve movement of the NP to the specifier of $[-i]$, just as in (33a), and, because $[-i]$'s specifier will be filled, it will be silent. The issue arises, specifically, with the comp-bare parse. This parse should lead to a definite reading of the bare noun, just as the spec-bare parse does, because the only difference between them is the $[X]$ feature, which is a purely syntactic aspect of a head. However, this prediction is not borne out. For instance, observe (41). Both of the sentences in (41) are intended as a list of people who came. (41a) provides this information with DPs of the form $\lceil \text{NOUN CLASSIFIER} \rceil$, which is known to be obligatorily definite (see (1b)). The second tries to provide the same information with bare nouns with $[-i]$. If bare nouns with $[-i]$ could have the definite reading, then we would not expect to see the difference that we observe between the $\lceil \text{NOUN CLASSIFIER} \rceil$ DP and the bare noun with $[-i]$.

- (41) a. $\text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{ele-}\text{ta} \text{ e-l-o,} \quad \text{ar} \text{ mee-}\text{ta} \text{ e-l-o.}$
 boy-CLF come-PFV-PST.3 and girl-CLF come-PFV-PST.3
 “The boy came, and the girl came.”
- b. $\# \text{t}^{\text{h}}\text{ele-}\text{i} \text{ e-l-o,} \quad \text{ar} \text{ mee-}\text{i} \text{ e-l-o.}$
 boy-FOC come-PFV-PST.3 and girl-FOC come-PFV-PST.3
Only possible readings, but contradictory:
 $\#$ “It’s a/the boy that came, and it’s a/the girl that came.”
Intended, but impossible reading:
 “The boy came, and the girl came.”

One way to describe the facts in (42) is that bare nouns with $[-i]$ are necessarily infelicitous in the context where a DP independently known to be definite is felicitous. The intuition is that, in (41b), both of the conjuncts provide exhaustive information about who came, which is why the entire conjunction itself becomes infelicitous. Since Bangla bare nouns are known to be interpretable both as an indefinite and a definite (as argued by [Simpson & Biswas 2016](#)), a straightforward way to formally describe this state of affairs is that, in (41b), each conjunct is a cleft whose pivot is either an indefinite or a definite depending on the context. Put differently, with bare nouns with an overt $[-i]$, the DP-internal scope of $[-i]$ seems to be unavailable, and only the DP-external scope (that is, the ordinary cleft reading) seems to be available.

Why this should be the case is definitely unclear. However, pursuing an idea suggested to me by Danny Fox (p.c.), one way to make sense of these facts is to think of the pronunciation rule for $[-i]$ — and the Doubly Filled Comp Filter, more broadly (see section 5.3 for why the two might be related) — as a ban on a head being overt when it is “too local” to the phrase it has attracted, where “a head being too local to a phrase” is defined as the phrase being sister to a projection of the head. Now, this “too local” criterion can be satisfied in at least two

ways: when a phrase is the sister, *i.e.*, complement, of a head and when a phrase is a specifier of the head. The first is instantiated by the spec-bare parse, discussed just above. The second is instantiated by the comp-bare parse, because there, the noun (phrase) is the complement of the *[-i]* head, and, because of the absence of the *[X]* feature, the noun (phrase) does not move any further. That is, if the pronunciation rule for *[-i]* is understood in the way just described, then the only possible pronunciation of the comp-bare parse will be just the bare noun itself, because the “too local” criterion is met there. This would explain why Bangla bare nouns with an overt *[-i]* only allows a DP-external scope of *[-i]*.¹⁴

The third remaining issue is that Sharvit-style *only* movement does not seem to be an option in the case of *[-i]* in Bangla, because if it were, then (42a) would not be infelicitous in the given context. The problem with (42a) seems to be that the contrast between Charu, an individual, and the number two, a degree, is odd. Since this oddness necessarily appears, it means that *[-i]* cannot associate with *Amol*, and it must associate with *two*. The intended reading with a contrast between Amol and Charu is possible only in (42b), where *[-i]* is pronounced adjacent to *Amol*. As discussed in the previous section, this is different from the behavior of *only*-movement.

- (42) **Context:** Amol and Charu have been in an accident. Amol has got cuts in two of his fingers, and Charu has got cuts in only one of her fingers.

- a. #*dmol-er du-to agul-i ket-etj^h-e. tjaru-r na.*
 Amol-GEN two-CLF finger-FOC cut-PERF-PRS.3 Charu-GEN NEG

Only possible reading:

“... It’s two of Amol’s fingers that have been cut. Not Charu’s”

Intended, but impossible reading:

“Only Amol has cut two of his fingers. Not Charu.”

- b. *dmol-er-i du-to agul ket-etj^h-e. tjaru-r na.*
Amol-GEN-FOC two-CLF finger cut-PERF-PRS.3 Charu-GEN NEG
 “Only Amol has cut two of his fingers. Not Charu.”

I do not have a solution at the moment for why *[-i]* differs from *only* in this way. One reason for this might be independent rules of pronunciation which prevent *[-i]* from associating with something that it is not pronounced adjacent to. Another relevant issue here might be

14. One could further object that, assuming (i) the spec-bare parse and the comp-bare parse involve the same basic structure, *modulo* the *[X]* feature, and (ii) *[-i]* takes as its complement the potentially moving noun (phrase) directly, then anti-locality (*e.g.*, Abels 2012, Bošković 1997, Branen 2021, Erlewine 2020, Grohmann 2003, *a.o.*) should prevent movement of the noun (phrase) in the spec-bare parse, and if additional structure is posited between *[-i]* and the noun (phrase), then the comp-bare parse will not meet the “too local” criterion. This is a rather fuzzy issue at the moment, because both the empirical and conceptual/theoretical status of anti-locality itself is debated. See, *e.g.*, Ershova & Bezrukov (2024). Given this, I would, at present, not consider issues pertaining to anti-locality as definite sources of worry and rely on future literature to resolve what anti-locality is, first.

the fact that focus-sensitive operators differ from each other in their mechanisms of focus-sensitivity. See, e.g., [Beaver & Clark \(2003, 2008\)](#), and also footnote 12. I would end by leaving these issues for a future occasion.

Glossing abbreviations

1	1st person
2	2nd person
3	3rd person
ACC	Accusative
CLF	Classifier
FOC	Focus
FUT	Future
GEN	Genitive
GER	Gerund
HAB	Habitual
IMPFV	Imperfective
LOC	Locative
NEG	Negation
NMLZ	Nominalizer
NOM	Nominative
PERF	Perfect
PFV	Perfective
PL	Plural
PRS	Present
Q _{Y/N}	Question particle in Yes/No questions
SG	Singular

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